# Keely and Du

## By Jane Martin

**Characters:** **KEELY:** a pregnant woman taken hostage by a militant anti abortion org, 20-30
**DU:** the woman assigned by the organization to be her caretaker & companion, 65
**The Setting:** A basement in Rhode Island, the present

## INTRODUCTION

*Keely, who was brutally raped by her ex-husband, is kidnapped by right-to-lifers before she can obtain an abortion. She is chained to a bed in a basement and told that she will be forced to carry the child to term. Du is a Bible Christian who cares for Keely. Here, these two very different women begin to find some common ground. Keely and Du by Jane Martin*

*(Lights up on Keely sitting up in bed eating breakfast.*

**DU:** (She watches as Keely eats around the eggs.) You ever try catsup?

**KEELY:** What, on eggs?

**DU:** Oh, we'd buy this spicy kind by the case, Lone Star Catsup. My brothers would heat up the bottles in boiling water so they could get it out faster. (A moment. Keely pokes at her eggs.)

**KEELY:** (Finally.) For what?

**DU:** Eggs, rice, they put it on cantaloupe which like to drove my mother from the house. (An involuntary smile from Keely, and then, sensing her complicity, silence.) So, he left high school, Cole?

**KEELY:** Listen...(Having started to say something about the situation, she thinks better of it, then her need to talk gets the better of her.) He took a factory job. He was into cars, he wanted this car. His uncle worked a canning line got him on. (A pause.)

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**DU:** And?

**KEELY:** We still went out. . . off and on. We got in an accident, we were both drunk, I got pretty cut up. My dad's cop pals leaned on him. After that. . . I don't know, lost touch. (A pause.)

**DU:** Lost touch.

**KEELY:** I don't want to get comfortable talking to you.

**DU:** Keely. . .

**KEELY:** Forget it.

**DU:** Please...

**KEELY:** I said forget it. (A long pause.) I'm going crazy in here. I could chew off my wrist here. That paint smear on the pipe up there, I hate that, you know? This floor. That long crack. Everywhere I look. Wherever I look, it makes me sick. (She tears up.) Come on, give me a break, will you. I gotta get out of here, I can't do this. (Mad at herself.) Damn it.

**DU:** (Gently.) Help us pass the time, Keely. You're not giving up. I know that. (Keely looks down.) You lost touch.

**KEELY:** Yeah. (A pause.) There were guys at school, you know, different crowds. . . 37 days, right? (Ou nods.) I wa . . . man. . . I was, umm, waitressing, actually before he left, down at the Gaslight. .. he didn't like me working. I just blew him off. (A moment.) If I talk, it's just talk. . . only talk, that's all . . . because this is shit, what you do to me, worse than that.

**DU:** Only talk.

**KEELY:** Because I don't buy this, you tell him I don't buy it. (Du nods. They sit. Then. . .) So I was at a Tammy Wynette concert, you know, somebody else's choice, and there he was, definitely his choice as I found out, and my date is . . . well, forget him, so we got together and it got hot really fast and we ended up getting married, which nobody I knew thought was a good idea, which made

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me really contrary which is a problem I have. . . like up to here. . . so, you know, what I said, we got married, plus. . . (Finishing the eggs.) The catsup's all right.

**DU:** Oh, it's good.

**KEELY:** I mean I knew who he was, and I did it anyway. I knew about the drinking, I knew about the temper, I don't know where my head was, in my pants, I guess.

**DU:** Well, I married a man deemed suitable and that can be another problem. There is only one way a man is revealed, and that is day in and day out. You can know a woman through what she says, but don't try it with a man.

**KEELY:** Yeah, he had a line. I even knew it was a line.

**DU:** I'll just take the tray.

**KEELY:** And I knew he drank. Oh, hey, he downpedaled it before we got married. . . way, way downpedaled. He would drink, say two, two drinks, say that was his limit, take me home, go out pour it down 'til ten in the morning, I found that out.

**DU:** They talk about drugs, but it's still drinking the majority of it, now I have never been drunk in my life, is that something? I'm often tempted so I'll know what I'm missing, yes ma'am, I've tried the marijuana.

**KEELY:** Bull.

**DU:** Oh I have, and it didn't do a thing for me, and that's a fact, and I've been in a men's room which I doubt you have, and I've kissed three men in one day, so don't you think you can lord it over me.

**KEELY:** You smoked?

**DU:** Oh, yes. Found the marijuana in my son's sock, sat on his bed, waiting 'till heard him come in the front door, lit up and let him come on up and find me there doing it. Shocked him down to his drawers I might say. . . straightened

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him up in a hurry. That's the one who's an accountant in Denver. All boys, I would have given my heart for a girl baby. (An awkward pause.) It's noisy, too many boys in a house.

**KEELY:** (A pause.) Suitable?

**DU:** What? Oh, suitable. I was keeping company with a slaughterhouse man who could pop your eyes out with his shirt off, but he was an atheist and a socialist and who knows what else, and that was one too many for my father so he ran him off and put me together with a nice German milkman whose father owned the dairy, if you see my point. August. His name, not the month. I married him at nineteen, in 1947 and two months later the dairy went under, so I got no money and he looked just terrible undressed. The fact is he was an uninteresting man, but he got into the storage business and turned out a good provider. Now, listen close here, we went along 'til he bored me perfectly silent, if you can imagine, and God found us pretty late when the kids were gone or near gone, and God found that man he turned him into a firebrand and an orator and a beacon to others, and I fell in love with him and that bed turned into a lake of flame and I was, so help me, bored no more, and that's a testimony. There is change possible where you never hope to find it, and that is the moral of my story, you can stop listening.

**KEELY:** Right.

**DU:** It is. Still nothing to look at but I just close my eyes. The children kept me in that marriage until it became a marriage and the love I bore them kept me alive until the marriage could catch up.

**KEELY:** So what am I supposed to be? Glad?

**DU:** Things do change.

**KEELY:** Yeah, they get worse. He drank more, he got meaner, he screwed around, got herpes, gave 'em to me. My dad got shot, Cole wanted to move to Arizona

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because he knew I'd have to take care of him. Pawned a lot of stuff, got himself a recliner. I'm waitressing, minimum wage, cashier at a car wash, 70 hours minimum, he drinks himself out of his job, real thoughtful, right? The recession came on, we just fought minute to minute anytime we laid eyes on each other, I said I wanted a divorce, he hit me, and I left. I was out of there 1 5 minutes after he hit me . . . I was a crazy, out-of-my-mind lunatic I lived with him all that time. Jesus! What the hell was I thinking of?

**DU:** It was a marriage, Keely.

**KEELY:** Yeah. After that, he was all over me. I'd look out the window, he'd be in the back yard. The grocery, the library, when I was hanging up laundry, walk into the same bar when I was on a date. He'd come down to the restaurant, say it was about borrowing money, but he knew I wasn't giving him money, forget that, he just liked me to be scared which is what I figured out. Then it stopped for six months, who knows why, then he came back, sent flowers, left messages, begged me to talk to him for one hour so I invited him over, you know, I thought we could sit down and let go of it. I thought I could take his hand and say we're clear, we're two different people. You know, some dumb ass idea like that. That we could just let it go, you know, be whole and be gone, you know what I mean? So I fixed him dinner, and he brought me this stuffed animal, and we were doing, well, not perfect but all right, and I just touched his arm s6 he would know it was alright, and he locked onto my hand, and I said" let go now," and he started in . . . said he needed. . . pulled me in, you know, hard, and I got a hand in his face, and he . . . he bit down. . . bit down hard, and I . . . I don't know, went nuts . . . bunch of stuff. . . got me down on the floor. . . got me down on the floor and raped me. That's how he caught up with our marriage, that's how he changed. (They sit in silence.)

**DU:** Change can start anytime.

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**KEELY:** I don't want to talk about it. (A pause.) You believe God sees you?

**DU:** I do.

**KEELY:** He sees you now?

**DU:** I believe he does. (A pause.) Keely? (No answer.) Doctor says you're in as good a fourth month as you can be.

**KEELY:** Let's give it a rest, okay?

**DU:** He says that baby is lively. (No response.) Almost time for your birthday. (A pause.)

**KEELY:** How do you know that?

**DU:** Now, Keely, that's the least of what I know, and you know it.

**KEELY:** From my driver's license.

**DU:** The man says you can have a cake.

**KEELY:** The man?

**DU:** The man in charge. (A moment.)

**KEELY:** If I do what, I can have a cake.

**DU:** Oh, a few pamphlets.

**KEELY:** I'm not reading that crap, I mean it. Don't you bring it anywhere near me.

**DU:** You're not afraid of information, are you, honey?

**KEELY:** You call that information.

**DU:** Well, there's facts to it.

**KEELY:** I'm not having a baby. I'm not having it and have somebody adopt it. I'm not having it and keeping it. It won't be. It won't. (A pause.)

**DU:** What would you like for your birthday, honey? (Keely looks at her.) Besides that. That's not in my power. (A pause. Will Keely speak?)

**KEELY:** I would like to get dressed. I never liked being in a nightgown. I don't like my own smell. I know that's crazy. You know how you can smell yourself on your night stuff.

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**DU:** Oh, I can share that. That's something that doesn't get a bit better with age, let me tell you.

**KEELY:** I want to stand up. I want my hands free, I don't care if it's for ten minutes, one minute. I want to walk into a bathroom. I want a chocolate cake. I want to stand up, not bent over on my birthday.

**DU:** Oh, honey. We only do this because we don't know what else to do. We can't think what else. . . I don't know, I don't. . . birthdays when they're little, the looks on those faces. . . those little hands. . .

**KEELY:** Little hands, little faces, you make me sick. . . Jesus, can you listen to yourself? All this crap about babies. You don't care about this baby, you just want it to be your little. . . I don't know. . . your little political something, right, God's little visual aid you can hold up at abortion clinics instead of those pickled miscarriages you usually tote around. . . hold up, Baby Tia, wasn't that the one you had downtown trying to pass it off like it was aborted? I can't believe you don't make yourself sick. . . throw up . . . you make me sick, how do you talk this garbage?

**DU:** (A moment.) I have that dress you had on . . . something the worse for wear. . . he might let me get it cleaned. . . cleaned for your birthday. (A moment.)

**KEELY:** I don't hate babies, if that's what you think.

**DU:** I know that.

**KEELY:** What the hell is your name? You can. . . you can. . . you can give me that for my birthday. I would like to know what the hell to call you when I talk to you!

**DU:** Du.

**KEELY:** What?

**DU:** I get called Du.

**KEELY:** Du.

**DU:** Uh-huh.

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**KEELY:** Du what? Du why? Never mind, forget it . . . I would like to be free for ten minutes on my birthday.

**DU:** You might have to read some pamphlets.

**KEELY:** What the hell happened to you, Du? Do you see where we are? Look at this where you got to. Look at me. You used to be a person sometime, right? You look like one. You sound like one. You see the movie Alien where they end up with snakes in their chests? What happened to you?

**DU:** They tear apart the babies, they poison them with chemicals, and burn them to death with salt solution, they take them out by Caesarean alive and let them die of neglect or strangulation, and then later on, these poor women, they cut their wrists or swallow lye, and then they bring themselves to me because I'm the nurse. Over and over. Over and over. Little hands. Little feet. I've held babies. I've lost babies. I took a baby through six months of chemotherapy and lost that baby. I need to sleep. That's what happened to me.

**KEELY:** (Almost gently.) I can't raise this baby, Du. I'm so angry and fucked up, I just can't do it. I dream of how it happened over and over all the time. I'd be angry at the baby, I think so. I'd hurt the baby sometime and might not even know it, that could happen. If I had a baby, my first one, and I gave it away, I'd just cry all the time, I would. I'm doing this on empty and, if I did that, I would be past empty and I don't know. I have such black moods, it frightens me. The baby would come out of being chained to a bed, you know what I mean. It's not my baby, it's the people's who made me have it, and I couldn't treat it as my baby, not even if I loved it, I couldn't. He'd come around, see. He wouldn't stay off if I had his baby. He would never, ever in this world leave off me, and I think sometime he'll kill me, that's all I can think. Or hurt the baby, whatever, however in his head he could get me, he would do . . .

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would do it. Really. And I can't have his baby. . . uh . . . it's just not something I can do . . . because I'm about this far, you know . . . right up to the edge of it . . . right there. . . right there. (A pause.) So I guess it's me or the baby, so I guess that's crazy, but you don't. . . I don't show you. . . just how. . . how angry I really am. I don't. I don't. (A pause.)

**DU:** He could have changed, Keely.

## SOURCE INFORMATION

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